

Multiple subjects

If a sentence contains more than one noun, and these nouns are joined by *and*, they almost always take a plural verb. These are known as compound subjects. Phrases such as *along with* and *as well as* separate the subjects, however. In these cases, the verb should agree with the first subject, regardless of whether the second subject is singular or plural. By contrast, if a singular subject is joined to a plural subject and separated by *or* or *nor*, the verb agrees with the nearest subject.

- When the phrase **the number of** precedes the subject of a sentence, the subject is considered to be singular: "The number of weights used **is** variable." By contrast, the phrase **a number of** makes a subject plural: "A number of different weights **are** used."
- Expressions of **quantity**, such as **time, money, weight, or fractions**, are treated in the same way as **collective nouns**. For example, "Half of Tyler's allowance **is** spent on exercise equipment."

Tyler and his brother Matt
are competing.

◁ **Compound subjects**
The subjects *Tyler* and *Matt* are acting together, and are joined by *and*, so they take the plural form.

Matt's size as well as his strength
is awesome.

◁ **Separate subjects**
The subjects *size* and *strength* are acting separately, so the verb is singular to match the first subject, *size*.

Neither Tyler's neck nor his arms
are small.

◁ **Mixed subjects**
The plural subject *arms* is closer to the verb than the singular subject *neck*, so the verb is plural. With mixed subjects, always put the plural subject closest to the verb.

Indefinite pronouns

Most indefinite pronouns can be easily identified as singular or plural. *Both*, *several*, *few*, and *many*, for example, are always plural. Some, however, are singular words that refer to plural things. These include *each*, *everyone*, and *everything*.

Number	Indefinite pronoun
singular	everybody, everyone, everything, somebody, someone, something, anybody, anyone, anything, nobody, no one, nothing, neither, another, each, either, one, other, much
plural	both, several, few, many, others
singular or plural	all, any, most, none, some

▽ Agreeing with prepositional phrases

Five indefinite pronouns can be singular or plural, depending on the context. These are *all*, *any*, *most*, *none*, and *some*. Only when these pronouns occur do prepositional phrases determine whether a verb should be singular or plural.

Most of the contest **is** over.

indefinite pronoun

This prepositional phrase is singular because the noun *contest* is singular, so the verb also has to be singular.

Most of the competitors **have** left.

This prepositional phrase is plural, because the noun *competitors* is plural.

The verb is plural to match the prepositional phrase.